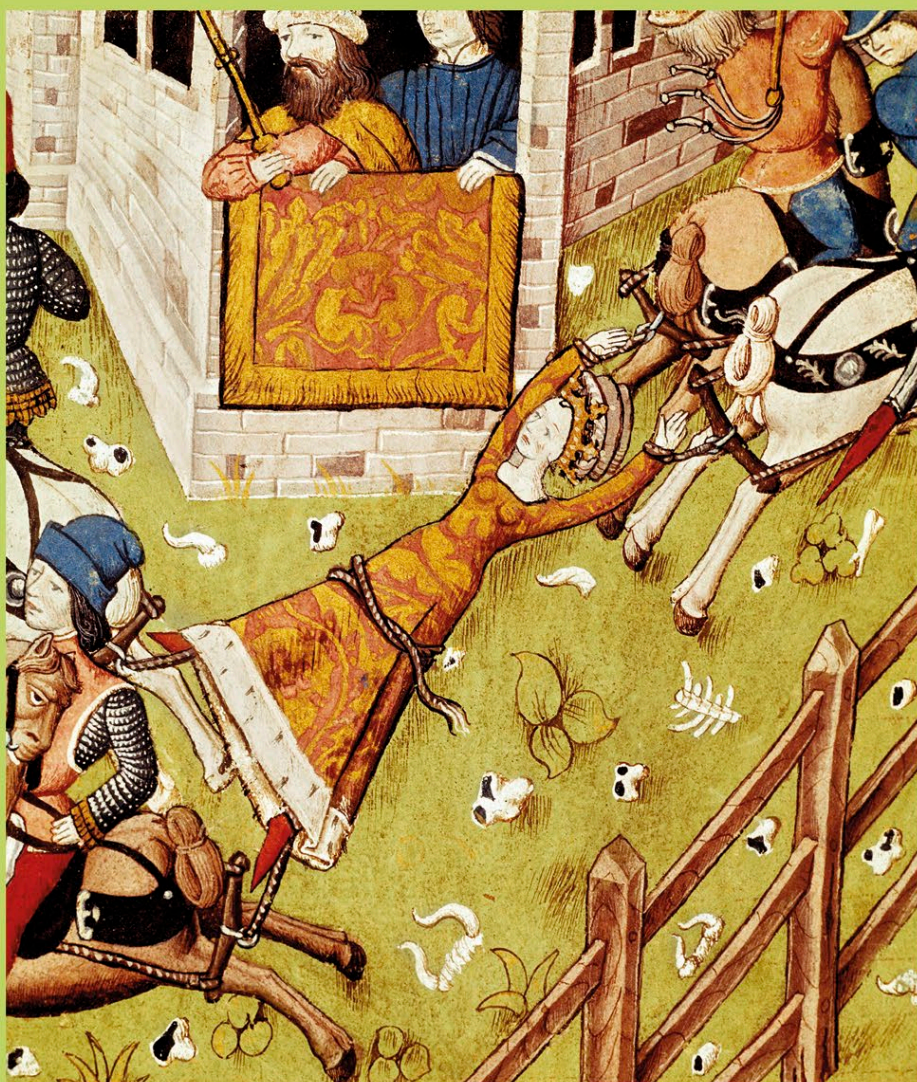


THROUGH THE AGES

Crime

Cast in their role as nurturers, women are depicted as far less likely to commit the most serious of crimes. Female offenders have often been harshly punished, not only for the crimes they commit but for the unwritten social codes that they break.



▲ Killer queen

Brunhilda, Queen of Austrasia (a 6th-century European kingdom), was put to death because of her feud with Fredegund, the murderous Queen of Soissons. The queen's son later had Brunhilda executed by being pulled apart by four horses.

WITH THE EXCEPTION OF prostitution, women have lower arrest rates than men for virtually all categories of crime. Between 1750 and 1815 in Europe, the majority of crimes committed by women—solicitation, robbery, and theft—were linked to their need for money, food, or resources. In the Victorian era, women were harshly punished: Emily Brennan, for example, twice received seven years of penal servitude for shoplifting.

The ultimate crimes

Female murderers have a distinct role in criminal history because many societies see killing as against women's supposedly innate nurturing nature. Consequently, when women have committed murder, they have been more severely condemned than men. Like men, women have killed for various reasons: some "black widows" married and

“
I have **no remorse**
... I **ain't killed**
nobody. I never
took anything
I **regretted.**

DORIS PAYNE, AMERICAN JEWEL
THIEF, 2015